

Chapter 26-1

Unfortunately, Liang Shi didn't pay attention to this last night.

Mainly because she didn't expect that Xu Qingzhu would have blackouts—to the extent that she wouldn't remember anything whenever she drank too much.

This could be considered a skill.

At least she didn't have it.

When she got drunk, she would occasionally do things that were out of line, but after sobering up, she would remember everything, sometimes even more clearly than usual.

She and Xu Qingzhu were two extremes, which is why she rarely got drunk normally.

Having spent many years in the entertainment industry, she had practiced quite a few techniques for deflecting alcohol.

Now she could basically escape unscathed from dinners and drinking parties of all sizes.

Since Xu Qingzhu had forgotten, Liang Shi also didn't have any malicious intention to remind her.

What happened last night wasn't exactly good memories anyway.

If Xu Qingzhu found out that after getting drunk, she had also been drugged with an aphrodisiac¹ and nearly lost her innocence after being seen naked, she would probably be unable to sleep all night.

However, Liang Shi still reminded her, "Don't go out drinking alone anymore."

Xu Qingzhu frowned, her cool voice sounding extremely cold, but with a rising intonation at the end, "Are you trying to control me?"

"No." Liang Shi was also lying on the bed, occupying only half her body's space, still keeping far away from Xu Qingzhu. She didn't even look at Xu Qingzhu, only saying gently, "This is just a suggestion. If you drink too much alone outside and your inhibitor fails, it will cause pheromone chaos. I can't always arrive at your side in time."

Moreover, sometimes she would feel so powerless that she wouldn't know what to do.

The original owner was too much of a bastard and had offended too many people.

This time it was Cheng Ran who showed mercy at the last moment, but what about next time?

Not every time could one escape unscathed from the hands of bad people.

"So, you care about me?" Xu Qingzhu asked frankly and openly, without a trace of flirtation.

This was clearly an ambiguous question that could even evolve into: Are you worried about me? Do you like me?

But when asked in her sexually cold voice, it cut off all fantasies.

It was particularly like asking, "Do you think the weather is nice today?"

Liang Shi nodded, "Mm."

—Mainly because I'm worried that if you die, I'll have to die with you.

"Mm?" Xu Qingzhu expressed confusion about her answer. "Why?"

Liang Shi smiled awkwardly, "You're my wife. Isn't it normal for me to care about you?"

Xu Qingzhu stared at her closely. Liang Shi lowered her eyelashes and reached out to turn off the brightest light in the room, leaving only the bedside lamp.

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu snorted, "How rare."

"Then what exactly do you care about regarding me?" Xu Qingzhu asked again.

Liang Shi: "..."

She thought for a moment, "I care about your body and worry about your emotions."

—As long as you're unhappy, the system will increase my bad luck value.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her, as if trying to see something on her face, but Liang Shi's disguise was very good.

Her expression was calm. After a while, she said to Xu Qingzhu again, "If you have any occasions where you must go drinking, you can call me to come along."

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow, "Can you help me drink?"

"I can help you deflect drinks." After Liang Shi finished speaking, she added, "If necessary, I can also drink. After all, as you know, I have a good alcohol tolerance."

Liang Shi wasn't too clear about this body's alcohol tolerance, but her previous alcohol tolerance had been pretty good.

However, the original owner had always been a party girl, so her alcohol tolerance shouldn't be worse than her previous one.

Xu Qingzhu closed her eyes, her voice faint, "I probably won't have any occasions requiring drinking. Yesterday was just an accident."

"Mm-hmm." Liang Shi said, "Then if you need to discuss business in the future, don't go to Huayue International². The Liang family owns quite a few restaurants under their name, you can go directly to those."

"Me discussing business?" Xu Qingzhu shook her head, "That's probably impossible."

Liang Shi: "..."

It's very possible, okay?

You're going to be reborn from the ashes in the future and become an Omega that everyone in Haizou City respects!

In this world, Alphas naturally had advantages over Omegas, especially in the workplace. Most industry elites were Alphas because Alphas didn't need to bear children, and even when a family had children, Alphas would take on the burden of supporting the family, so leaders preferred Alphas.

Therefore, it was quite difficult for Omegas to stand out in the workplace.

But Xu Qingzhu could do it.

However...

Liang Shi suddenly thought that in the original book, Xu Qingzhu had her glands removed by the original owner, and after meeting her pursuer—the later official Alpha Lu Jiayi—with Lu Jiayi's help, she brought the Xu family's Minghui Jewelry back from the brink of death. She even grew it bigger step by step, obtained angel round funding, and successfully went public, becoming Minghui Group.

And the original owner's glands were removed by another of Xu Qingzhu's pursuers, Chen Liuying.

But now Xu Qingzhu hadn't had her glands removed.

Once her body remained in this world, it meant that Xu Qingzhu would never suffer such harm again. So would she still be reborn from the ashes?

Footnotes:

¹ **迷情劑 (míqíng jì)** - An aphrodisiac or love potion; a drug used to arouse sexual desire, commonly used in Chinese web novels as a plot device

² **華悅國際 (Huayue International)** - A high-end establishment that appeared earlier in the story, where dangerous situations involving drugging occurred

Chapter 26-2

For the first time, Liang Shi realized that her arrival might bring about a butterfly effect to this world.

Would Xu Qingzhu still meet Lu Jiayi in the future?

Suddenly, a mechanical voice sounded: [Don't worry, the main content of the book won't change.]

Liang Shi: "Are you monitoring me?"

System: [Just happened to hear it, replying to you.]

Liang Shi: "...Then while you're at it, answer me this—will Xu Qingzhu revive the company and become the person in power at Minghui Group?"

The system was silent for two seconds, [This is classified information, cannot be disclosed.]

Liang Shi: "?"

Then what's the point of you saying anything?

Liang Shi wanted to ask more, but the system immediately said: [Host, keep it up! The system has deposited the ten thousand yuan reward, please spend it all quickly. Friendly reminder: if you spend this money all on Xu Qingzhu, your luck value might increase.]

Liang Shi: "Why 'might'?"

System: [Because it's a probability event. The random drop of luck value depends on your European luck¹.]

Liang Shi gave up hope.

Her luck had never been very good.

She had never won the lottery, but when her assistant bought tickets with her, the assistant could win twenty thousand.

When she participated in giveaway activities, even if only two people retweeted—a fifty-fifty chance—she still wouldn't win.

But she was quite lucky for the people around her.

People who had bought lottery tickets with her had basically all won prizes, and they were all five-digit amounts.

As for her, she got nothing.

After learning this, she asked: "Fine. Can I save this money without spending it?"

Liang Shi wanted to save it for when she left the Liang family later, to prepare for emergencies.

System: [You can. PS: But if you have money and don't spend it, are you stupid?]

Liang Shi: "...?"

Before she could retort, the system quickly groveled: [Sorry, the little system didn't think it through. Host please don't be angry, the little system knows it was wrong.]

Liang Shi: "..."

Could this system have some backbone?

"Let's discuss something." Liang Shi said: "Can you stop using speech particles in the future?"

System: [Ah? Why?]

Liang Shi: "...It's quite disgusting."

System: [Oh.]

Liang Shi said mercilessly, "Just like when you first came, be a cold and ruthless AI, don't learn human speech patterns to disgust me."

System: [...]

From then on, her mind became quiet.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu waved her hand in front of her eyes, "What are you thinking about?"

Liang Shi suddenly snapped back to attention, shaking her head, "Nothing..."

"You've maintained this posture for a minute." Xu Qingzhu said: "This is very strange."

Liang Shi had just been conversing with the system in her mind. To outsiders, it looked like spacing out, but when she communicated with the system, she would shut out all external distractions.

It seemed that in the future, she couldn't communicate with the system in front of people—it would be easy to cause problems.

If she suddenly did this on the street, people would think she had gone stupid.

Liang Shi pressed her brow, explaining: "Suddenly felt a bit tired, spaced out for a moment."

Xu Qingzhu asked: "What did you do today?"

Liang Shi: "Went back to the old mansion."

Xu Qingzhu stopped talking.

In the enclosed room, on the same bed, although there were two separate blankets, as long as neither of them spoke and let the room fall into silence, they could hear each other's breathing and heartbeats.

Liang Shi guessed that Xu Qingzhu was also afraid of awkwardness, which is why she kept looking for topics.

And now she didn't know what topic to find anymore.

Xu Qingzhu was the same.

Liang Shi usually had excellent composure, but at this moment she also felt it was too awkward, so she could only yawn and pretend to feel sleepy, "So sleepy, I'll sleep first."

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Mm."

After Liang Shi finished speaking, she turned around, leaving only her back to Xu Qingzhu, and conveniently turned off the lamp on her side.

Xu Qingzhu also turned off the lamp on her side, and the room immediately fell into darkness.

In darkness, a person's senses would be infinitely magnified.

Especially since Alphas' perception was more sensitive than others, so now she could hear every breath of Xu Qingzhu very clearly. She had no choice but to adjust her own breathing to match Xu Qingzhu's breathing.

In five minutes, Xu Qingzhu turned over twice and sighed three times.

Liang Shi couldn't sleep either.

When Xu Qingzhu turned over for the third time, Liang Shi turned on the lamp on her side.

Xu Qingzhu's breathing hitched, then she sat up, "Sorry, I disturbed you."

"It's fine." Liang Shi said: "I can't sleep either."

Xu Qingzhu opened the bedside drawer and took out an all-English novel, "I'll go downstairs to read, you rest."

Liang Shi immediately said: "Wait."

Xu Qingzhu's steps paused, "Mm?"

"How about we watch a movie?" Liang Shi said, "Maybe we'll fall asleep after watching a movie."

There was a projector in the room, which would also allow Liang Shi to complete that passive task.

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow, "Are you sure? Go downstairs to watch?"

Liang Shi smiled, "No need, going downstairs would disturb Yaya. Isn't there a projector in the room? We can use that to watch."

Xu Qingzhu pursed her lips and hesitated.

"Is there something wrong?" Liang Shi asked, "Do you prefer reading?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu said: "Either is fine with me."

"Then..." Liang Shi was about to open the drawer to get the remote control, but just as her hand gripped the drawer handle, Xu Qingzhu said: "The projector in the room is broken."

Liang Shi: "...Ah, well then."

Her tone couldn't hide her disappointment, making one want to tease her.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her and said in a flat tone: "Did you forget?"

Liang Shi: "Ah? What?"

Xu Qingzhu smiled slightly, "Last time when I was watching a movie in the room, Liang Shi came in and directly smashed the projector."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Sleep early." Xu Qingzhu said, "I'll go downstairs to read."

Liang Shi: "..."

Until Xu Qingzhu went out, she still looked confused.

Was it her?

No, it was the original owner?

When someone was just watching a movie peacefully, was it necessary to smash their projector?

The original owner was a psycho.

Wait.

Why did Xu Qingzhu say "Liang Shi"?

She was right across from her, why didn't she say "you"?

Had Xu Qingzhu already discovered something?

Or was she deliberately testing her?

Footnotes:

¹ 歐氣 (ōuqì) - "European luck" - Internet slang referring to extremely good luck, originating from gaming communities where European players were stereotypically considered to have better luck with random drops than Asian players

Chapter 26-3

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Could this also be a test?

Liang Shi wasn't clear about it, but in any case, Xu Qingzhu had definitely noticed something.

Her attitude when talking to herself was much gentler than before. Liang Shi certainly didn't think it was because she had recently made changes and been a little nicer to Xu Qingzhu that she got this good attitude in return.

What a joke. If someone treated her like the original owner did, she would never forgive them for the rest of her life, and would even wish for that person to die as miserably as possible.

How could she forgive so easily?

There were only two possibilities.

One was that Xu Qingzhu deeply loved the original owner, and as long as the original owner showed even the slightest change, she would immediately have a change of heart and show a smiling face to the original owner.

But this possibility was extremely slim and could be passed over without hesitation.

Xu Qingzhu didn't seem like someone with a love-brain.

She might have had good feelings for the original owner at some point, but after being hurt, she would definitely wrap up her heart tightly and not let the original owner have another chance to hurt her.

So there was only the second possibility.

Xu Qingzhu had discovered that she wasn't the original Liang Shi, but also didn't know where she came from.

Science couldn't explain this abnormal phenomenon. As a top student, Xu Qingzhu was extremely cautious, so she constantly tested her in daily life.

After figuring this out, Liang Shi unexpectedly felt relieved.

After all, she didn't need to keep pretending in front of Xu Qingzhu. From now on, if she didn't remember something, she didn't remember; if she didn't know something, she didn't know. There was no need to be secretive about it.

Given Xu Qingzhu's caution, she wouldn't expose her without absolute certainty.

Liang Shi lay back down on the bed. She had been lying when she said she wasn't tired just now—she was actually dead tired. She hadn't slept well last night, and during the day she had gone to the Liang family home, leaving her physically and mentally exhausted.

It was just that with someone lying beside her, she couldn't fall asleep.

Now that there was only her left on the bed, although Xu Qingzhu's scent still lingered in the air, it didn't affect her much.

Before sleeping, she remembered to set an alarm and quickly fell asleep.

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Xu Qingzhu curled up on the downstairs sofa reading a novel.

Having slept for a day and night, she wasn't particularly tired.

But her body was weak. After reading for less than two hours, her eyes became dry and sore, and she couldn't concentrate on reading anymore.

She had to close the book and rub her eyes downstairs. Guessing that Liang Shi had already fallen asleep, she unhurriedly went upstairs.

She opened the door very gently, afraid of waking the sleeping person.

A lamp was on in the room, just illuminating the doorway.

When she left, she had clearly turned on the lamp on Liang Shi's side, near the balcony, but when she returned, the lamp on her side was on, perfectly lighting her path back to bed.

Liang Shi's sleeping posture was very proper. She lay flat with her hands resting on her abdomen, breathing lightly.

Xu Qingzhu walked over and sat on the bed, causing one side of the bed to sink slightly.

Liang Shi didn't stir, seemingly fast asleep.

Xu Qingzhu put the book in the drawer, then slowly moved onto the bed, leaning against it and looking sideways at her.

Liang Shi recently hadn't been wearing makeup, or rather, she wore light makeup.

The previous Liang Shi would always wear makeup no matter how late she came home, and it was heavy makeup.

She liked all sorts of inappropriate colors, especially lipstick—she was basically a clearance handler for unsold colors, just relying on her good looks to mess around.

Several times, Xu Qingzhu had seen her sleeping on the sofa with makeup on.

But the current Liang Shi, although she had the same face as before, her eyes were completely different.

Some people say that to judge a person's character, you should look at whether their eyes are bright.

If her eyes are bright as stars, then she must be a person of upright character.

The previous Liang Shi's eyes had no luster, only deep hatred for this world, and sometimes, she would even show that expression of wishing everyone would die.

But the current Liang Shi's eyes always radiated a gentle luster.

Xu Qingzhu was someone good at observing details, just like how the current Liang Shi would hide all her behaviors in the details.

Except for that time in the hospital when she rashly carried strawberries into the ward and brazenly said she would change, hoping that she could trust her, all other times she was calm and gentle.

She always seemed to emit a faint scent of white tea¹.

Very reassuring.

During the time when grandfather passed away, Xu Qingzhu's room would always have a pot of white tea brewing.

She habitually fell asleep smelling that scent, as if grandfather had never left.

She smelled that reassuring scent again.

But she really couldn't confirm who Liang Shi really was.

Where did she come from?

She sat there, her gaze tracing over the other person's features inch by inch.

She still thought she looked better without makeup.

But... what did it have to do with her?

In any case, she was going to divorce Liang Shi.

She didn't want to follow her father's words and use marriage as a bargaining chip to exchange for the company's survival, nor did she want grandfather's life's work to come to nothing.

She had to enter the company, even if father opposed it.

Speaking of which, the last time she sent a message to father, his reply was only two words: "Not allowed."

Father felt that if she married into a good family, married an Alpha who was good to her, that would be the best thing for her life.

But he forgot that she had been first place since childhood, entered Qingyi University² with high scores, and even obtained an MBA degree.

If she hadn't been unwilling to go too far from home back then, she should have gone abroad for further study.

It was also for the company, and for a little bit of her own selfishness, that she chose marriage.

But what had this marriage brought him?

Only endless pain and constant fear.

Xu Qingzhu sighed lightly. In the middle of the night, she always couldn't help thinking about these things, worrying about them.

She decided not to listen to father's decisions anymore, and sent a message to her uncle who also worked at the company, saying that she planned to go to work at the company and needed him to arrange a position for her. There was no need to parachute in and squeeze out existing employees—she just needed an opportunity that would let her work at the company, preferably in the company's core departments, either the design department or exhibition department.

For a jewelry company, the design department was the core. Without excellent designs that could surpass competitors, it would never be able to establish itself in the industry.

The exhibition department was responsible for shows when new products were released each year, from hiring models to defining each piece of jewelry, indirectly affecting the sales of every new product.

Equally important were the advertising department and marketing department.

Every marketing plan determined whether jewelry could be seen by the public at first glance and arouse consumers' love. The era of "good wine needs no bush"³ had passed. In today's era, marketing was an indispensable link.

Xu Qingzhu's major should be most suitable for the human resources management department, but she still decided to go to a more essential place.

If she wanted to completely reverse Minghui's current situation, she would inevitably have to pull out the rotten roots directly. Bringing in new people would be meaningless—it would just be grafting new shoots onto rotten roots, which would rot sooner or later.

Uncle quickly replied, telling her to come anytime. The design department happened to have a management-level vacancy, and she could take it directly when she came.

Parachuting in seemed to be the fastest way nowadays.

Xu Qingzhu replied to him: [Okay, thank you, uncle.]

After a few seconds, she replied again: [I'll report for duty tomorrow.]

¹ 白茶 (báichá) - White tea, a delicate type of Chinese tea known for its subtle, calming fragrance

² 青翼大學 (Qīngyì University) - A fictional prestigious university in this story

³ 酒香不怕巷子深 - Chinese idiom literally meaning "good wine needs no bush" or "the fragrance of wine is not afraid of deep alleys," referring to the idea that quality products will naturally attract customers without heavy marketing

Chapter 26-4

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Early the next morning, Liang Shi was woken up by her alarm clock.

She had slept quite comfortably. When she woke up, she immediately turned off the alarm, afraid of waking Xu Qingzhu. But after turning off the alarm, she turned around and found that Xu Qingzhu was already gone.

She reached to the side and felt that the bed sheets were cold.

Had Xu Qingzhu not come back to sleep in the room last night?

While thinking about this, Liang Shi tied up her hair and went to the bathroom to wash up.

Today was her first day reporting to Dongheng Group, so naturally she couldn't go with a bare face. But she didn't put on heavy makeup either—she simply applied foundation, lipstick and daily eyeshadow, and brushed on a layer of mascara to make her eyelashes curled and long.

While brushing her eyelashes, she thought of Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu's eyelashes seemed to be long and curled enough without mascara.

Thinking this way, her hand became slightly unsteady, and the mascara brush got on the area under her eyes, creating a black smudge.

She immediately looked for tissue to wipe it off, but this mascara was waterproof and quick-drying.

Wiping it only made the area under her eyes even blacker, like she had dark circles.

Liang Shi: "..."

Even makeup veterans would have accidents sometimes.

How ridiculous.

She looked for makeup remover on the cosmetics shelf but didn't find any.

She went back to the room and looked on Xu Qingzhu's vanity table, but didn't see any at first glance.

With no choice, she could only pick up the bottles one by one to read the labels, but many of the cosmetics had no Chinese characters—either strings of Korean text or bottles full of Japanese. The most recognizable one was actually a bottle with all English text, but when Liang Shi looked at it, she found it was a bottle of lotion.

"..."

Liang Shi was helpless. She was trying her best to translate the last bottle on the table that looked somewhat like makeup remover when the bedroom door was pushed open.

Xu Qingzhu walked in.

Liang Shi: "..."

Wasn't it a bit inappropriate to touch someone else's things without asking?

Under Xu Qingzhu's gaze, Liang Shi finally developed a bit of not-quite-conscious awareness.

Holding the bottle in her hand, she said with some difficulty: "I'm looking for makeup remover."

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her, finding it hard to ignore the large black smudge under her eyes.

She asked calmly: "Did your eyeshadow smear?"

"No." Liang Shi said: "I accidentally smudged the mascara when I was brushing it on."

Xu Qingzhu walked in, "I see."

She walked to the desk and took out a round box from the drawer that Liang Shi had never seen before.

When the box opened, it contained neatly laid makeup remover pads that gave off a slight alcohol scent.

Xu Qingzhu handed it to her, "What's on the table are all daily skincare products."

"I see." Liang Shi thanked her, "Thank you."

Liang Shi took the box of makeup remover pads into the bathroom. She carefully wiped while looking in the mirror, but the mirror reflected Xu Qingzhu's face.

Xu Qingzhu was standing at the doorway, staring straight at her.

Liang Shi: "..."

She couldn't help asking: "Did I kick you last night?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu said: "You sleep very well."

"Then..." Liang Shi couldn't help it, "Are you looking for me for something?"

Xu Qingzhu paused slightly, "Not exactly."

What did "not exactly" mean? Either there was something or there wasn't—what was "not exactly"?

Moreover, she was already having trouble with her makeup, and now being stared at like this was quite unnerving.

Liang Shi let out a soft breath, "Then you..."

"Alright, there is something." Xu Qingzhu interrupted her, "I'm going to work today."

Liang Shi felt relieved, "I see, then go ahead. Are you going to your own family's company?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded, "I get off work at six in the evening, but I might work overtime. If I come back very late, you don't need to wait for me for dinner."

"Okay, got it." Liang Shi went along with her words: "I'm also going to work. I didn't like the HR department that my second brother arranged for me before, so this time I'm going to try a newly established department. It should also be six o'clock off work, but I guess the new department will work overtime, so my work hours aren't fixed either. If I'm not back by dinner time, you don't need to wait for me either."

Xu Qingzhu nodded, "Okay."

This negotiation was quite pleasant, and after the negotiation ended, Liang Shi continued struggling with the mirror.

She didn't really want to remove all the makeup on her face for this small smudge, so she could only use a corner of the makeup remover pad to wipe it away, then touch up with foundation afterward—it wouldn't be too troublesome.

But Xu Qingzhu kept standing at the doorway, not leaving even after they had exchanged all the information.

Liang Shi: "..."

Even when she used to be stared at by more than ten cameras and needed close-up shots, she hadn't been this nervous.

Liang Shi couldn't help it, "Is there anything else?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head, "No."

She answered frankly, but just wouldn't leave.

Liang Shi lowered her hand and asked again: "Do you need to use the bathroom?"

Xu Qingzhu still shook her head, "If I need to, I can go downstairs."

Liang Shi: "..."

Then what are you doing here?

She held back again and again, barely managing not to say this out loud.

To avoid making Xu Qingzhu unhappy and having the system increase her bad luck value.

The main thing was that with Xu Qingzhu standing there, she would get nervous.

And when she got nervous, her hands would shake.

This smudge was caused by unconsciously thinking about Xu Qingzhu's eyelashes and accidentally smearing it.

And now she had to watch.

Liang Shi felt helpless and thought she might as well give up—at worst she'd remove all the makeup and wash her face.

After she turned on the faucet, Xu Qingzhu suddenly spoke up, "Are you not good at applying makeup?"

Liang Shi: "...?"

"How could that be?" Liang Shi immediately denied it, "My makeup skills are pretty good."

Actually, she had even been a beauty blogger for a while.

Because makeup took so long when filming, she would always observe the cosmetics on the table.

Later, when she was bored, she would livestream and chat with fans about what cosmetics were good to use recently, and when she was even more bored, she would even do makeup cosplay.

Though it was all cosplaying anime characters.

She had just had an accident, and this accident happened to be seen by Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu walked in. She turned off the faucet, didn't say whether she believed it or not, but took out a new makeup remover pad from the box.

She folded it twice on her finger.

Then she looked up at Liang Shi and said, "Lower your head."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Ah?" Liang Shi was surprised, but still did as told. She bent down slightly, but still kept some distance from Xu Qingzhu. Xu Qingzhu stood on her tiptoes slightly, raised her hand, and placed the folded makeup remover pad over Liang Shi's lower eyelid.

Not too much, not too little.

It covered everything perfectly without blocking Liang Shi's vision.

Chapter 26-5

Today was Xu Qingzhu's first day at work, and she dressed in a professional style.

She wore form-fitting black trousers that made her legs look very long, with a blue and white striped short-sleeved tight top on top. If worn alone, it would be a crop top, but paired with the pants it was just right, revealing only a small gap that gave glimpses of her cold white skin. It would go well with either a suit jacket or a casual-style outer layer.

Actually, when it came to wearing clothes, it still depended on the face.

No matter what style, Xu Qingzhu probably wouldn't look ugly in it.

The main thing was that Omegas would have slight secondary breast development after their heat period, and she was wearing a tight top.

With the two of them close together, that softness would brush against her inadvertently.

Liang Shi's gaze wandered randomly, always catching glimpses of that softness unintentionally, but if she lowered her eyelids, she would see Xu Qingzhu's face directly.

She must have gotten up very early and had already applied exquisite makeup, a relatively typical no-makeup makeup look.

There wasn't much makeup effect, making her look very pure.

Xu Qingzhu stood on her tiptoes, but Liang Shi's head kept rising higher, unconsciously lifting up.

Seeing that she was about to be out of reach, Xu Qingzhu directly grabbed her collar and pulled down, bringing their faces close together again.

Xu Qingzhu's fingers, separated by a makeup remover pad, gently brushed over the skin around Liang Shi's eyes.

Her expression was serious and frank, without a hint of flirtation. Her pupils were brown and could perfectly reflect Liang Shi's face.

She frowned as she spoke, "What are you dodging?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"Nothing." Liang Shi's voice lacked confidence, "I... you..."

She stammered twice.

This actually made Xu Qingzhu laugh. Her lipstick was bean paste colored, very moisturizing, with maximum visual impact.

Xu Qingzhu blinked and teased with a smile, "I'm not preparing to kill you."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi suddenly remembered a song that had been popular all over the streets before she transmigrated.

There was a lyric in it that was frequently modified.

But she liked the original version best, which went: "The evening stars are like your eyes, killing and setting fires¹."

"I'm not." Liang Shi swallowed, "Are you... are you done wiping?"

Xu Qingzhu moved her hand away to look, then covered it again, "Not yet, your mascara is good quality."

Her breath fell on Liang Shi's face as she spoke, making Liang Shi's face slightly red.

Morning was naturally a time when desires awakened, like spring.

If she were alone, the morning would naturally pass peacefully without distraction, but now there was another person beside her, especially one with such a face.

Whether physiologically or psychologically, she probably couldn't resist.

Just when Liang Shi was holding her breath until she could barely breathe, Xu Qingzhu finally withdrew, releasing her grip on the collar and even smoothing out the collar area with her hand.

She threw the used makeup remover pad into the trash can, her cool voice as cold as always, "All done, just touch up with foundation and brush your eyelashes again."

"Okay, thank you." When Liang Shi said this, she had a feeling of having survived a disaster.

Xu Qingzhu stood to the side and asked, "Do you need me to help you apply mascara?"

Liang Shi: "...No need."

Absolutely not necessary.

"Then I'll go out first." Xu Qingzhu said, "Come down to eat when you're done."

Liang Shi: "..."

She was somewhat surprised—why was Xu Qingzhu being so nice to her?

Before she could figure it out, Xu Qingzhu walked to the bedroom door, then turned back around, pondered for a moment and said, "Liang Shi."

Liang Shi had just pulled out the mascara and was glad she hadn't started applying it yet. She turned around and responded: "Mm?"

"Thank you." Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi: "?"

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When she went downstairs to eat, Liang Shi finally learned the reason.

It was Xu Qingya who had vividly recounted what happened that day to Xu Qingzhu, though she skipped over what happened in the room, only saying that Liang Shi had rushed in regardless of everything to save her, and then when she acted drunk and crazy in the car, it was also Liang Shi who patiently coaxed her.

Afterward, she had called a family doctor and stayed up all night taking care of her.

Liang Shi admired Xu Qingya's storytelling ability.

She also admired her thoughtfulness in embellishing and beautifying her actions.

Both Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu had to go to work, while Xu Qingya hadn't started school yet and was still staying at their house.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu went back to their room to get their things.

Liang Shi felt she knew a bit more than Xu Qingzhu, so after checking everything once, she reminded her, "Remember to bring your ID, you'll need it when reporting in."

Xu Qingzhu nodded, "Okay."

Just before leaving, Xu Qingzhu hesitantly asked, "When you brought me out that day, did you see Weiwei?"

Liang Shi was startled, "No, Zhao Xuning went to save her, she should be fine, right?"

When she went in, she had looked at her watch—it was 10:10 at the time.

Even if she had been injected with an aphrodisiac, that amount of time would only be enough to take off clothes and share a kiss. Nothing deeper could have happened, right?

So she was more inclined to think the other person was fine.

"What's wrong?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head, "I can't contact Weiwei."

"What about Zhao Xuning?"

"Can't contact him either."

"Let me try." Liang Shi said: "I'll ask Zhao Xuning what's going on, then tell you."

"Okay." Xu Qingzhu paused, "Thank you."

Liang Shi: "No problem."

She felt like Xu Qingzhu was saying thank you too frequently.

But none of this mattered much.

It was Liang Shi's first day at work, going to what was essentially an unfamiliar field, and she had expectations for it.

She didn't drive that Porsche worth a million, offering it to Xu Qingzhu, but Xu Qingzhu also declined.

She picked out a silver-white car from the garage, probably worth around two hundred thousand, which was the most low-key one in the garage.

Xu Qingzhu also drove a car worth around two hundred thousand.

Neither of them wanted to be too high-profile.

They drove out together, separating at Tinglin Road².

Footnotes:

¹ 殺人又放火 - "Killing and setting fires" is a Chinese idiom meaning to cause great harm or destruction. In this context, it's used poetically to describe how captivating someone's eyes are

² 亭林路 (Tínglín Road) - A fictional street name in the story where their paths diverge

Chapter 26-6

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Dongheng Group's headquarters wasn't particularly eye-catching among the CBD buildings.

Liang Shi went to the HR department with her documents to report in. The colleagues here had all seen her before.

To be precise, they had seen the original owner.

They all had a poor impression of her—just a spoiled rich young lady with weird outfits and a bad temper.

However, Liang Shi wasn't here to change their impression of her. She dutifully entered her information, then the department head called the design department head to come pick her up.

As soon as the words left her mouth, an irritated roar came through the phone: "What kind of parachute soldier is being dropped in now? Can't she read signs or recognize words? Anyone who can't even find their own department should be fired early. Our design department doesn't want her."

Click.

The phone was hung up.

The HR department head looked at Liang Shi awkwardly and fearfully, afraid that she would have a young miss tantrum and directly trash the office. She trembled for a long time not knowing what to say.

Liang Shi didn't make things difficult for her, just smiled and said, "I'll go over myself."

Department head: "Ah?"

She paused, "How about I take you there instead?"

"No need." Liang Shi said: "You're busy, I can read, I'll find it myself."

Department head: "..."

She had a feeling that Miss Liang not tearing apart the HR department office was her showing restraint, and she was waiting to go tear apart the design department instead.

She couldn't help but light a candle in her heart for that hot-tempered design department head.

Liang Shi left and took the elevator to the 12th floor.

The 12th floor was in chaos. The newly established department was understaffed with too much work, and the responsibilities of each department weren't completely clear yet. Although they had hired a chief editor with many years of magazine experience, she had previously worked in print media and was almost completely disconnected from new media.

The company's upper management paid special attention to this department, wanting to use it to get a piece of the new media magazine market and thus have their own promotional channel.

They had a topic selection meeting with the general manager in the afternoon, but they were still completely clueless.

All the directions submitted by the planning department had been rejected by the department head.

As soon as Liang Shi walked in, she heard that irritated voice roaring on the phone: "Are you all pigs? Top university graduates with three years of digital magazine experience, and the topics you submit are all this kind of stuff? How can any of this be used? All of this has been written to death already—who's going to read it? And this one, pandering for traffic—do you have any journalistic integrity left? The topic selection meeting is this afternoon, and you can't even decide on the most basic things. What the hell are we supposed to discuss?"

Everyone was gathered around having a meeting, and all the workstations were empty.

Only a little girl sat in a corner position, reading a fairy tale book.

The little girl looked about the same age as Lingdang¹. Even though the outside world was noisy and chaotic, she remained immersed in the world of books.

Liang Shi stood there for ten minutes without anyone noticing her.

Until the department head said, "I'm giving you half an hour to submit new topics. We need to move quickly to the next step. Alright, meeting dismissed."

Everyone breathed a sigh of relief and scattered like birds and beasts.

When they turned around and saw a strikingly beautiful woman, they were all stunned.

A round-faced girl turned around and said, "Department head, there's a new person here."

The department head had her hair meticulously combed back, with too much hair gel making it look very greasy. She adjusted her glasses and looked over at Liang Shi, "Are you the new one?"

Liang Shi nodded, "Yes."

The department head stared at her for a while, "Here to be a model?"

"No, here to do copywriting, or interviews." Liang Shi said.

"What did you major in?"

"Chinese Language and Literature."

"Which school?"

Liang Shi really didn't want to mention the original owner's third-rate diploma mill, but she could only bite the bullet and say: "Guangliu University²."

Everyone in the office was shocked.

How did someone with such trashy credentials get into Dongheng?

You should know that everyone present had graduated from top domestic universities.

So they looked at her with some disdain.

Liang Shi didn't mind. The department head paused and said, "Then you'll go to the copywriting team."

Liang Shi's workstation was also in the periphery, right next to that little girl. She had nothing to do all morning.

She sat there bored until noon, caused quite a stir when she went to the cafeteria for lunch, then hurriedly finished eating and returned to her workstation.

Near the start of work, she went to the restroom again.

Soon after, a bunch of people came in.

Every company's restroom was a place for everyone to gossip, and Dongheng was no exception.

From their voices, they were people from the magazine department.

It was Liang Shi's first day, and she hadn't completely memorized everyone yet.

At first they were discussing her, talking about how someone with such poor academic credentials had managed to get into Dongheng.

"When I was eating lunch, I heard someone say her background seems quite significant—even our General Manager Liang has to give her some face."

"Really? Then what's she doing in our magazine department?"

"That office in HR that's now used as a meeting room, remember? That used to be her office."

"Damn, she's a big shot."

"These types are the most annoying—can't do anything but you can't say anything either."

"..."

They discussed for a while, and Liang Shi had heard enough. She was about to leave when someone suddenly exclaimed.

"What's wrong?" someone asked.

"Chen Liuying's agent jumped off a building." That person said, "She was just sent to the hospital."

"Who? That Chen Liuying who became famous overnight? The one called the number one imperial Alpha³?"

"Yeah, I saw the gossip reports saying the agent went to Huayue International to drink with people to get resources for her, got assaulted, and couldn't handle it so she jumped."

"The entertainment industry is just like that, but looking at it this way, Chen Liuying isn't a good person either."

Liang Shi perked up her ears to listen to their discussion.

Chen Liuying, who would later remove the original owner's glands, had appeared.

She was a celebrity.

She took out her phone to check, and what popped up were all today's hot news.

They were all discussing Chen Liuying's agent's suicide attempt, and when Liang Shi scrolled down, she immediately frowned.

Chen Liuying's agent was—Bai Weiwei.

Footnotes:

¹ 鈴铛 (Língdāng) - A young girl mentioned earlier in the story, whose name means "little bell"

² 光流大學 (Guāngliú University) - A fictional low-tier university in the story

³ 第一禦A (dì yī yù A) - "Number one imperial Alpha" - a title referring to a dominant, powerful Alpha character, likely in the entertainment industry